voters were split, between Herzog, Lapid, and the liberal Meretz party. A handful gave their votes to the Joint List—though the party won only a few thousand Jewish votes, far short of the 35,000, one seat's worth, that it had hoped to win.

So the mood at the Zionist Camp's party was oddly subdued. It turned grim around 9.30 pm, half an hour before the polls closed, when exit polls from Israel's three main television networks began to leak out. Producers from Army Radio whispered about a survey that showed Likud in a dead heat with the Zionist Camp. Outside the arena, an ashen-faced staffer pulled aside one of the party's top parliamentarians. "We didn't pull it off," she said, downcast.

There was a brief cheer inside the arena when the official exit polls were broadcast at 10 pm. None were good. Two showed a tie, the third a one-seat advantage for Likud. All showed the Zionist Camp with twenty-seven seats, the party's best showing in sixteen years, but without a clear path to coalition. It was hard to mask the sense of disappointment. The best that Herzog could hope for was an unwieldy unity government, rotating the premiership with a resurrected Netanyahu.

When Herzog finally appeared to speak, well after midnight, he told the crowd to leave. "You can all go home now and get some sleep," he told his supporters, who dutifully complied. "There won't be any decisions made tonight."

"Simmering from within"

In 1996 Israel had started a short-lived political experiment, allowing voters to elect a candidate directly for prime minister. The exit polls on election night had shown a victory for the Labor Party's Shimon Peres. But the polls had got it wrong. He had lost the election by less than 30,000 votes, giving Netanyahu his first term as premier. A phrase entered the political lexicon. "We went to bed with Peres, and woke up with Netanyahu."

Nineteen years later, we went to bed with Netanyahu, but a chastened Netanyahu, one who might have to share power. We woke up to a triumphant Netanyahu: with 99 per cent of the ballots counted, he suddenly had thirty seats, compared to the Zionist Camp's twenty-four. The exit polls had missed a last-minute surge in Likud votes, which gave him the closest thing to a commanding victory that is possible in Israel's fractious political